

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Software Product Management English



Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For software product managers, product owners, UX leads, engineering managers, growth product teams, platform PMs, and product-operations staff.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Product Discovery and Problem Framing

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Roadmaps and Prioritization

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

03 User Stories and Acceptance Criteria

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

04 Metrics, Funnels, and Product Analytics

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

05 Experimentation and A/B Testing

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

06 Release Readiness and Go-to-Market

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

07 Platform, APIs, and Technical Debt

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

08 Stakeholder Pushback and Executive Narrative

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

Product Discovery and Problem Framing

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

A stakeholder requests a new button without explaining the user problem. Support notes mention difficulty finding an existing action.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

user need - Something a user needs to accomplish in a particular context.

persona - A research-informed representation of a user group used to guide design or communication.

use case - A specific situation describing how someone uses a product or service to achieve a goal.

opportunity cost - The value of the best alternative given up when choosing an option.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Compare this wording: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 01 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when starts the review?
 - B. Could you confirm when the review starts?
 - C. Could you confirm when does the review start?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?
 - B. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?
 - C. Who will present the report at the meeting?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Find the action before adding another button

Fictional discovery discussion using the lesson case: a stakeholder requests a button, while support notes describe difficulty finding an existing action.

01 • Sales stakeholder: Could you add a new export button to the home screen in the next release?

02 • Product manager: Which user need would it address? Support notes mention difficulty finding the existing export action.

03 • Sales stakeholder: Customers ask our team where to download their records. I assumed another button would solve that.

04 • Product manager: That suggests a discoverability problem, but we haven't established the best solution or affected persona yet.

05 • Sales stakeholder: Could we look at the support examples before deciding where any new control belongs?

06 • Product manager: Yes. Let's clarify who was trying to export, from which page, and for what use case.

07 • Sales stakeholder: I don't have those details here. I'll bring the original notes rather than invent a typical customer.

08 • Product manager: Good. We should also consider opportunity cost before committing development capacity to a proposed solution.

09 • Sales stakeholder: I'll describe the request as an export-discovery question, not an approved home-screen feature.

10 • Product manager: Then we can investigate the problem and compare possible responses with the evidence in view.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Who needs the weekly digest?

Fictional discovery interview: a department lead requests a weekly email digest but has not identified recipients or decisions it should support.

01 • Department lead: Our product needs a weekly email digest. Can that go straight into the backlog?

02 • Product researcher: What decision would recipients make from it, and which people would actually receive the message?

03 • Department lead: I had managers in mind, but I haven't asked whether they need weekly summaries.

04 • Product researcher: Then the recipient persona and frequency are assumptions. Could we explore the underlying reporting task first?

05 • Department lead: Managers sometimes ask for project updates. I don't know whether email is their preferred channel.

06 • Product researcher: That's useful context, not confirmation of a digest use case. Can we speak with those managers?

07 • Department lead: Yes. I'll introduce you and avoid promising a feature before we understand their workflow.

08 • Product researcher: I'll ask what they currently review, what is missing, and what happens when information arrives late.

09 • Department lead: Can the discovery conversation also reveal whether an existing view already meets part of the need?

10 • Product researcher: Absolutely. That helps us compare options and avoid spending capacity before the problem is clear.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A competitor feature is not a user problem

Fictional roadmap intake: a stakeholder asks for color-coded folders because a competitor offers them; no customer use case has been established.

01 • Marketing lead: A competitor has color-coded folders. Should we match that feature before our next announcement?

02 • Product manager: What user problem would colors solve in our product, beyond making the feature lists look similar?

03 • Marketing lead: Possibly faster organization, but that's my interpretation rather than something customers have told us.

04 • Product manager: Then let's keep it as a hypothesis and identify a concrete organization task to investigate.

05 • Marketing lead: Could we ask people who manage many folders how they currently find the right one?

06 • Product manager: Yes. We should learn their use case and constraints without leading them toward colors as the answer.

07 • Marketing lead: I can help recruit relevant users, although we haven't defined that persona precisely yet.

08 • Product manager: Let's define the recruitment criteria together and consider the opportunity cost of any proposed build.

09 • Marketing lead: I'll hold the launch claim until we have a problem statement and a prioritization decision.

10 • Product manager: Good. Competitive information can prompt a question without dictating the solution we eventually choose.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Product Discovery and Problem Framing

A stakeholder requests a new button without explaining the user problem. Support notes mention difficulty finding an existing action.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: What is the user trying to achieve, and where do they get stuck? Let's examine that problem before deciding whether a new button is the right solution.

Scenario 2 | Why do users ask for printing?

A fictional support queue contains four requests for a print button. The records do not explain whether users need paper copies, portable files, or approval evidence. Clarify the use case before proposing a feature.

Role A: Product manager: ask what task sits behind the request.

Role B: Support lead: explain the limited evidence and offer to follow up with the requesters.

Possible opening: We have four requests for printing, but we haven't established what users need the output for.

Success checks

- Separate requested solution from underlying need.
- Identify missing audience and task information.
- Agree a focused follow-up without promising implementation.

Add a complication: A stakeholder says four identical feature requests prove one identical need.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Roadmaps and Prioritization

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

SITUATION

A roadmap has three large features and capacity for two. All three sponsors describe their request as urgent.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

roadmap - A plan showing intended product or organizational direction over time, with varying levels of commitment.

prioritization - Deliberate ordering of work based on value, urgency, risk, capacity, and dependencies.

dependency - Work, approval, input, vendor, system, or decision that another activity relies on.

capacity - Available people, assets, time, space, or system throughput for a given workload.

3. Notice the language

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Compare this wording: If you will approve the scope, we can assess the schedule.

LESSON 02 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Offer a workable tradeoff

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence presents a normal future condition clearly?
 - A. If the scope changes, we will review the schedule.
 - B. If the scope will change, we will review the schedule.
 - C. If the scope changes, we reviewed the schedule.
2. Which response negotiates a new request without silently promising extra work?
 - A. We have included it, although its scope has not been reviewed.
 - B. We guarantee the original date without assessing the addition.
 - C. We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Three priorities, capacity for two

Separate fictional roadmap case: saved filters, bulk export, and team templates each require four team-weeks. Eight team-weeks are available this quarter. Engineering has also assessed a personal-template slice at two team-weeks. Later capacity and stakeholder approval are unconfirmed.

01 • Portfolio sponsor: Saved filters, bulk export, and team templates are all urgent. Can we deliver all three?

02 • Product manager: They total twelve team-weeks, but this quarter has eight. We need a scope or timing tradeoff.

03 • Portfolio sponsor: Give me two concrete options rather than another request to prioritize everything.

04 • Product manager: Option one: filters and export this quarter, if sponsors agree; propose team templates for a later confirmed slot.

05 • Portfolio sponsor: And an option that gives template users something sooner, even with a narrower scope?

06 • Product manager: Option two: filters plus the assessed personal-template slice, if accepted; defer export and shared templates.

07 • Portfolio sponsor: That uses six weeks. Could the remaining two finish bulk export as well?

08 • Product manager: No, export requires four. Spare capacity doesn't complete that feature; later delivery still needs confirmation.

09 • Portfolio sponsor: I prefer option two, subject to template users accepting personal scope and the export sponsor agreeing.

10 • Product manager: I'll seek those decisions before changing the roadmap; later dates remain uncommitted.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A dependency changes the order, not the goal

Fictional planning: a new reporting view depends on an account-permissions update; both are proposed for the same planning period.

01 • Business sponsor: The reporting view is more visible. Can we build it before the account-permissions update?

02 • Product manager: The proposed view depends on that update. Reversing the order may leave the view unable to work.

03 • Business sponsor: Could the team start the visual design while the permissions dependency is being addressed?

04 • Product manager: That may be possible, but parallel preparation isn't the same as completing the dependent feature first.

05 • Business sponsor: Please show that distinction in the roadmap so stakeholders don't mistake an early mockup for delivery.

06 • Product manager: Agreed. I'll ask the engineering lead which tasks can overlap and which require the dependency.

07 • Business sponsor: If overlap isn't feasible, could we move the reporting commitment rather than pretend capacity increased?

08 • Product manager: Yes. We'll compare that timing option with any reviewed scope reduction that still provides user value.

09 • Business sponsor: I can support a conditional plan, provided the dependency and expected decision point are clear.

10 • Product manager: I'll bring the assessed sequence before we convert the proposal into a delivery commitment.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Urgent intake after the roadmap is agreed

Fictional product planning: a new sponsor requests a bulk-edit feature after the team has committed its available capacity; no estimate exists.

01 • Operations sponsor: We need bulk editing urgently. Can you add it to the already agreed roadmap?

02 • Product manager: We can assess the request, but current capacity is committed and we have no estimate yet.

03 • Operations sponsor: Could we call it a small enhancement so it doesn't displace anything already promised?

04 • Product manager: The label doesn't establish effort. We need to understand the use case, dependencies, and testing scope.

05 • Operations sponsor: Then what can we negotiate now before the estimate is available from engineering?

06 • Product manager: We can clarify urgency and identify which existing outcome you would consider postponing if necessary.

07 • Operations sponsor: I can discuss priorities, but I cannot approve moving another sponsor's committed work alone.

08 • Product manager: I'll bring both sponsors into that tradeoff discussion once we have an assessed option.

09 • Operations sponsor: Please acknowledge the request without telling users that bulk editing has a confirmed delivery date.

10 • Product manager: Agreed. The roadmap changes only after the relevant scope, capacity, and approval questions are resolved.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Roadmaps and Prioritization

A roadmap has three large features and capacity for two. All three sponsors describe their request as urgent.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Second round: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Model for scenario 1: We have capacity for two features in this period. Could we compare the expected outcomes and dependencies, then agree which item moves? Calling all three urgent does not resolve the capacity choice.

Scenario 2 | A smaller pilot instead of a full rollout

A fictional product team can assess a pilot for one department or a full rollout to four. Estimates and support needs are not yet known. A sponsor wants all four immediately. Negotiate the information and conditions needed for a smaller option.

Role A: Product manager: offer a pilot assessment without guaranteeing its delivery date.

Role B: Sponsor: explain the desired reach and consider a bounded first step.

Possible opening: Could we assess a one-department pilot while we clarify the capacity and support needs for all four?

Success checks

- Distinguish pilot scope from full rollout.
- Keep estimates and capacity unconfirmed.
- Agree the evidence needed for prioritization.

Add a complication: The sponsor wants the pilot labeled a complete rollout on the roadmap.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

User Stories and Acceptance Criteria

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

SITUATION

A user story says the page should load "quickly." The team needs a testable completion condition.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

user story - A concise description of a user's goal and the value a product capability should provide.

acceptance criteria - Specific conditions a deliverable must meet to be accepted.

edge case - An unusual or boundary condition a product or process may need to handle.

definition of done - An agreed description of the work required before an item is considered complete.

3. Notice the language

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Compare this wording: Please revert soonest with the necessary.

LESSON 03 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask for an actionable next step

4. Check the language

1. What does 'Please send it by Thursday' normally mean?
 - A. Send it on Thursday, but not earlier.
 - B. Keep sending it regularly until Thursday.
 - C. Send it no later than Thursday.
2. Which request gives the recipient enough detail to act?
 - A. Could you confirm that you received my earlier message?
 - B. Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?
 - C. Could you confirm that the review is important?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Make quickly testable

Fictional refinement using the lesson case: a user story says a page should load quickly without defining a measurable completion condition.

01 • Quality engineer: The user story says quickly. Could you specify what timing and conditions would count as acceptable?

02 • Product manager: I haven't agreed a threshold yet. We should clarify the user expectation before choosing a number.

03 • Quality engineer: Please include where timing starts and ends, plus the representative data and device conditions.

04 • Product manager: That will help us avoid a test that passes only because it measures a different interaction.

05 • Quality engineer: Exactly. Can we review proposed acceptance criteria before the team commits to the story?

06 • Product manager: Yes. I'll bring the user context and ask engineering for feasible measurement conditions at refinement.

07 • Quality engineer: Should the definition of done replace those story-specific criteria if it already requires testing?

08 • Product manager: No. The shared completion checklist doesn't define what quickly means for this particular page.

09 • Quality engineer: I'll keep the timing criterion open and identify empty and large-data cases for discussion.

10 • Product manager: Good. We can agree a testable boundary without inventing a performance promise today.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

What should happen when there are no results?

Fictional search-story review: the story describes displaying matching records but says nothing about a search with zero matches.

01 • Frontend developer: The story covers matching records. What should users see when the search returns no results?

02 • Product owner: That edge case isn't defined. We need a deliberate empty-state behavior rather than an accidental blank panel.

03 • Frontend developer: Could you clarify whether the search term stays visible so users can revise it?

04 • Product owner: I propose keeping it visible, but let's confirm the interaction with design before treating that as approved.

05 • Frontend developer: Please bring the proposed behavior to tomorrow's refinement so I can estimate the complete story.

06 • Product owner: I'll include the no-results case in the acceptance-criteria discussion and ask quality to review it.

07 • Frontend developer: Should an unavailable search service show the same empty state because both return no displayed records?

08 • Product owner: No, those are distinct situations to specify. Missing matches shouldn't be confused with a failed search.

09 • Frontend developer: I'll identify both cases and leave their final behavior pending the refinement decision.

10 • Product owner: Then we'll have explicit criteria instead of discovering the missing distinction during acceptance testing.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Saved locally or shared with the team?

Fictional story discussion: a requirement says save the filter, but does not specify whether it belongs to one user or the whole team.

01 • Backend developer: When this story says save the filter, whose future sessions should use that saved setting?

02 • Product owner: I intended a personal filter, but the story doesn't make that ownership clear.

03 • Backend developer: Please confirm whether personal means this device only or the user's account across devices.

04 • Product owner: That remains undecided. I'll ask the product designer to clarify the intended use case with me.

05 • Backend developer: Could we resolve it before estimation? The persistence and access expectations affect the implementation scope.

06 • Product owner: Yes. I'll request that decision at refinement and include the resulting acceptance criteria.

07 • Backend developer: We should also discuss the edge case where a saved filter refers to a removed category.

08 • Product owner: Agreed. Let's define that behavior explicitly instead of assuming the general definition of done covers it.

09 • Backend developer: I'll bring the technical questions, but I won't silently choose account-wide storage as the product requirement.

10 • Product owner: Thank you. We'll close refinement with the ownership boundary and any remaining decision clearly recorded.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | User Stories and Acceptance Criteria

A user story says the page should load "quickly." The team needs a testable completion condition.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Second round: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Model for scenario 1: Could we define the relevant user journey, measurement conditions, and acceptable response time? That will make the acceptance criteria clear enough for development and testing.

Scenario 2 | Cancel after an upload starts

A fictional upload story includes a Cancel control, but its behavior after transfer begins is undefined. No cancellation semantics have been approved. Request a bounded acceptance-criteria discussion covering user feedback and the saved-item state.

Role A: Quality engineer: ask what cancellation should mean at this stage.

Role B: Product owner: identify the decision needed and coordinate with engineering.

Possible opening: Could we define what Cancel does after transfer starts, including what the user sees afterward?

Success checks

- Distinguish visual feedback from actual item state.
- Request clear conditions before testing.
- Agree a review owner and realistic discussion point.

Add a complication: A colleague says any disappearance of the progress bar should count as success.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

Metrics, Funnels, and Product Analytics

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

SITUATION

A product dashboard shows more sign-ups but fewer users completing setup. A stakeholder calls the acquisition campaign a complete success.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

activation - The point at which a new user completes a defined first valuable action.

retention - Keeping customers, users, staff, or records over a stated period; specify which meaning applies.

funnel - A sequence of stages people move through toward a defined outcome.

cohort - A defined group sharing a characteristic or starting event for analysis over time.

3. Notice the language

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Compare this wording: We need to operationalize the implementation.

LESSON 04 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Make a complex point clear

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence explains 'backlog' rather than repeating it?
 - A. The backlog is the maximum work the team can finish in a period.
 - B. The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.
 - C. The backlog is the work completed during the last period.
2. Which follow-up best checks whether your explanation was clear?
 - A. How would you describe the next step in your own words?
 - B. Would you like me to repeat the explanation?
 - C. Was the explanation detailed enough for you?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

More sign-ups, fewer completed setups

Fictional analytics discussion using the lesson case: sign-ups increased but fewer users completed setup; a stakeholder calls the campaign a complete success.

01 • Marketing stakeholder: Sign-ups increased, so I called the acquisition campaign a complete product success in the update.

02 • Product analyst: Sign-ups improved, but fewer users completed setup. Those stages tell us different things.

03 • Marketing stakeholder: Could you explain activation without implying every sign-up should be counted as an active user?

04 • Product analyst: Here activation is reaching the defined setup milestone. Signing up enters the funnel but doesn't complete it.

05 • Marketing stakeholder: Then acquisition performance can improve while the next stage still raises a concern.

06 • Product analyst: Exactly. We should inspect consistent cohorts and definitions before attributing the setup change to the campaign.

07 • Marketing stakeholder: Does this evidence tell us whether those users will stay, or is retention another question?

08 • Product analyst: Retention is another question about continued use over time, not established by this setup count.

09 • Marketing stakeholder: I'll narrow the success claim to sign-ups and make the setup issue visible.

10 • Product analyst: I'll bring the funnel breakdown and any comparability gaps before we recommend a response.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A returning visit is not the defined retention event

Fictional product dashboard: retention is defined as completing a project task in a later week, but a draft counts any returning page view.

01 • Product manager: The draft retention chart counts returning page views. Is that our agreed retained-user definition?

02 • Product analyst: No. Our current definition requires completing a project task in a later week.

03 • Product manager: Then a visit and a retained user are not interchangeable measures for this report.

04 • Product analyst: Correct. A returning visit shows activity, but it doesn't establish the task-based milestone we agreed.

05 • Product manager: Could you explain that distinction on the chart without suggesting page views have no analytical value?

06 • Product analyst: I'll label them as visits and calculate retention separately using the defined event and cohort.

07 • Product manager: Do we know whether the required completion events are available for every week in the comparison?

08 • Product analyst: That coverage still needs checking. I'll flag missing periods rather than count them as zero retention.

09 • Product manager: Good. Keep the metric definition and observation window visible when you bring the revised view.

10 • Product analyst: Then readers can distinguish engagement activity from the specific retention measure we actually use.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A younger cohort has had less time

Fictional funnel review: an older sign-up cohort has seven days of setup observation; a newer cohort has only two days.

01 • Growth manager: The newer cohort has fewer completed setups. Does that prove the new onboarding flow performs worse?

02 • Product analyst: Not yet. The older cohort has seven observation days, while the newer one has only two.

03 • Growth manager: So we are comparing different opportunities to reach activation, not simply different interface versions.

04 • Product analyst: Exactly. A cohort groups users by a shared starting event, but the observation window still matters.

05 • Growth manager: Could you compare both cohorts at day two instead of waiting another five days?

06 • Product analyst: That could provide an early matched view if the required event history is available.

07 • Growth manager: And a day-two comparison wouldn't establish the seven-day result or long-term retention.

08 • Product analyst: Correct. We should label the chosen window and keep later outcomes separate.

09 • Growth manager: I'll remove the immediate failure claim and ask for the matched early funnel view.

10 • Product analyst: I'll check event coverage and bring the comparison with its timing boundary clearly stated.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Metrics, Funnels, and Product Analytics

A product dashboard shows more sign-ups but fewer users completing setup. A stakeholder calls the acquisition campaign a complete success.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: Sign-ups increased, but setup completion fell. These metrics describe different stages of the funnel. Let's examine the full journey before concluding that the change improved the intended user outcome.

Scenario 2 | One user makes five accounts

A fictional sign-up dashboard counts accounts, while an activation report counts unique people. One test participant created five accounts. The extent of multiple accounts elsewhere is unknown. Explain why the two measures cannot be treated as the same unit.

Role A: Product analyst: explain accounts versus people.

Role B: Growth lead: ask what definition and reconciliation are needed.

Possible opening: The sign-up figure counts accounts, but the activation report counts people, so their units differ.

Success checks

- Distinguish the counting units.
- Avoid generalizing from one participant.
- Agree a consistent definition before comparing funnel stages.

Add a complication: The growth lead proposes dividing every account total by five.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Experimentation and A/B Testing

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

An A/B test shows a higher conversion rate in one version after one day. The planned test duration has not elapsed.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

A/B test - Controlled comparison of two variants to estimate the effect of a change on a defined outcome.

hypothesis - A proposed explanation or prediction that can be examined using evidence.

guardrail metric - A measure monitored to detect an unwanted consequence of an experiment or change.

statistical significance - A result meeting a specified statistical test threshold under its assumptions; it does not establish practical importance or causation.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Compare this wording: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 05 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change may have contributed to the delay.
 - B. The change must have caused the delay.
 - C. The change definitely caused the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...
 - B. Across the service, the observed result was ...
 - C. In this pilot, the observed result was ...

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

One day of lift is not a completed test

Fictional A/B-test review using the lesson case: one version has higher conversion after one day, before the planned duration ends.

01 • Growth lead: Version B has higher conversion after one day. Can we end the A/B test and launch it?

02 • Experiment analyst: The planned duration hasn't elapsed. The observed difference isn't yet the completed readout we agreed to use.

03 • Growth lead: Are you saying the higher rate is false, or that our conclusion should stay provisional?

04 • Experiment analyst: The observed rate stands. The interpretation needs the planned analysis, including uncertainty and guardrail metrics.

05 • Growth lead: Could statistical significance alone settle the rollout decision if a dashboard happens to display it today?

06 • Experiment analyst: It wouldn't replace the decision plan or review of practical effects and possible harms.

07 • Growth lead: Then I'll report early directional results without describing the hypothesis as confirmed.

08 • Experiment analyst: Good. We'll continue following the agreed monitoring and decision process, including any established safety escalation.

09 • Growth lead: Please tell me what is observed now and what remains pending at the next check-in.

10 • Experiment analyst: I'll bring those separately so one encouraging day doesn't become an unsupported product conclusion.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Conversion improves while support contacts rise

Fictional experiment readout: the treatment shows higher conversion and more support contacts; uncertainty and the prespecified guardrail evaluation are pending.

01 • Product manager: The treatment converts more users. Can our recommendation focus on that improvement alone?

02 • Experiment owner: Support contacts also increased, and the guardrail evaluation is pending. That belongs in the same discussion.

03 • Product manager: Does the increase prove users were confused by the treatment, or is that an interpretation?

04 • Experiment owner: It is an interpretation. We observed more contacts, but haven't established their cause or composition.

05 • Product manager: Then please separate the contact count from the hypothesis about confusion in the readout.

06 • Experiment owner: I will. We'll also assess uncertainty and the predefined guardrail rather than invent a threshold afterward.

07 • Product manager: Could a conversion gain still be practically unattractive if support workload rises enough?

08 • Experiment owner: Potentially. That tradeoff needs the actual evidence and agreed decision criteria, not just one favorable metric.

09 • Product manager: I'll leave the rollout recommendation open until that combined assessment is available.

10 • Experiment owner: I'll bring the benefit, guardrail result, and unresolved attribution questions together for review.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

The test changed two things at once

Fictional product experiment: version B changes both a headline and button placement; the observed conversion rate is higher than version A.

01 • Designer: Version B converted more users, so the new headline must be the reason.

02 • Experiment analyst: B also moved the button. The comparison doesn't isolate the headline from that layout change.

03 • Designer: Then our hypothesis about the headline alone isn't directly tested by this combined treatment.

04 • Experiment analyst: Correct. We can discuss the observed combination while keeping individual-component explanations unconfirmed.

05 • Designer: Would a statistically significant combined effect prove that both changes helped independently?

06 • Experiment analyst: No. It would not establish each component's contribution or rule out interactions between them.

07 • Designer: I'll describe B as the combined version and remove the headline-only claim from the review.

08 • Experiment analyst: Please keep the exact treatment description with the result so future readers know what changed.

09 • Designer: If we need the individual contribution, we'll propose a separate experiment rather than rewrite this one's history.

10 • Experiment analyst: Agreed. First complete the planned readout, including guardrails, before deciding what further question to test.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Experimentation and A/B Testing

An A/B test shows a higher conversion rate in one version after one day. The planned test duration has not elapsed.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: The early observed rate is higher, but the planned test is incomplete. I'll report it as an interim result and check the agreed analysis and guardrail measures before recommending a decision.

Scenario 2 | The slide and dashboard disagree on the treatment label

A fictional test dashboard identifies the treatment as B, but a draft slide calls A the treatment. No published readout has been sent. Discuss how to verify assignments and correct the presentation before interpreting results.

Role A: Experiment analyst: request the assignment record and treatment definition.

Role B: Product manager: pause the conclusion and confirm the correction route.

Possible opening: The slide and dashboard disagree about the treatment label, so we need to verify assignment before interpreting the result.

Success checks

- Verify labels from the source record.
- Do not select a treatment identity from outcome size.
- Agree a corrected readout with uncertainty and guardrails retained.

Add a complication: A stakeholder says the larger number can simply be labeled the winner.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

Release Readiness and Go-to-Market

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

SITUATION

A release is ready for review, but the support team has not received migration notes. The launch checklist lists them as required.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

release - Authorization to make a product available or proceed to a next stage, depending on the field.

rollback - Returning a system or release to a previous state under an agreed process.

enablement - Resources and preparation that help a team perform a role effectively.

migration - Moving data, users, or operations from one system or arrangement to another.

3. Notice the language

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

Compare this wording: Someone should follow up on this.

LESSON 06 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Transfer information and responsibility

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence checks that responsibility has been accepted?
 - A. I mentioned the check in my earlier email.
 - B. The check appears somewhere in the notes.
 - C. Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check.
2. Which response best checks a critical handoff detail?
 - A. I saw the message, so no clarification is needed.
 - B. So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct?
 - C. I assume all results are final, so we can finish.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Support has not received the migration notes

Fictional release handoff using the lesson case: a release is ready for review, but required migration notes have not reached support.

01 • Release manager: The release is ready for review. Have you received the migration notes required by our checklist?

02 • Support lead: No. We have the feature summary, but not the instructions explaining the customer migration changes.

03 • Release manager: Then support enablement remains incomplete. I shouldn't describe the overall launch handoff as finished.

04 • Support lead: Please identify the migration-note owner and the version we should review when it arrives.

05 • Release manager: I'll contact the owner and request the reviewed notes through our release channel.

06 • Support lead: Does receiving the file mean we have accepted the handoff, or should we confirm understanding too?

07 • Release manager: Please confirm you can access it and raise any unresolved support questions before readiness is assessed.

08 • Support lead: We also need the relevant rollback information identified, not assumed from an older release.

09 • Release manager: I'll include that request and keep launch readiness pending the required checklist review.

10 • Support lead: Understood. We'll acknowledge the actual materials received and make any remaining enablement gaps explicit.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A rollback link points to the previous release

Fictional release preparation: the current checklist links to a previous release's rollback notes; applicability has not been checked.

01 • Support engineer: The rollback link opens last month's notes. Are those instructions confirmed for this release?

02 • Release coordinator: Not yet. I'll ask the release owner to verify applicability rather than assume the link is sufficient.

03 • Support engineer: Please include the correct release identifier in the handoff so we can distinguish the versions.

04 • Release coordinator: Agreed. The current package is awaiting that check, even though the link itself opens successfully.

05 • Support engineer: Can I mark documentation accessible while keeping rollback readiness pending in our acceptance response?

06 • Release coordinator: Yes. Those are separate checks, and your acknowledgment should preserve that distinction.

07 • Support engineer: Who should receive questions if the verified notes describe a customer migration that support hasn't practiced?

08 • Release coordinator: I'll identify the migration owner and arrange a readiness discussion before the handoff is considered complete.

09 • Support engineer: I'll confirm receipt of the corrected package and repeat any constraints in our response.

10 • Release coordinator: Thank you. A working link won't be treated as evidence that the receiving team has applicable guidance.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Feature enabled is not customer migration complete

Fictional staged launch: a feature flag is enabled for a pilot group, while migration confirmation from that group is pending.

01 • Product manager: The pilot feature flag is enabled. Can support tell the pilot customers their migration is complete?

02 • Release engineer: Not yet. Enabling access and confirming each customer's migration are separate steps in this launch.

03 • Product manager: What should the receiving support team be able to confirm from your handoff today?

04 • Release engineer: The pilot scope, enabled configuration, and the fact that migration confirmation remains pending.

05 • Product manager: Please make clear that the feature isn't enabled for every customer in the wider release audience.

06 • Release engineer: I will. I'll include the pilot boundary and point to the migration-status owner.

07 • Product manager: Should support use the old rollout announcement as their customer response until a new one arrives?

08 • Release engineer: Only reviewed, applicable communication should be used; the old announcement may describe a different scope.

09 • Product manager: I'll coordinate the current wording and ask support to acknowledge the pilot limitation explicitly.

10 • Release engineer: Then our handoff will distinguish enabled access, confirmed migration, and broader launch readiness accurately.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Release Readiness and Go-to-Market

A release is ready for review, but the support team has not received migration notes. The launch checklist lists them as required.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

Second round: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Model for scenario 1: The product checks are ready for review; support preparation is still open. I'll send the migration notes and ask the support owner to confirm readiness before the launch decision.

Scenario 2 | The receiving team cannot access the demo

A fictional support-enablement session needs a demonstration environment. The release notes are available, but support accounts cannot enter the demo. No training has occurred. Give a handoff and agree the missing readiness check.

Role A: Release coordinator: acknowledge the access gap and name the next owner request.

Role B: Support lead: confirm received notes without claiming training completion.

Possible opening: We have the release notes, but demo access is blocked, so support practice has not happened yet.

Success checks

- Distinguish attendance, access, and completed practice.
- Request an access update through the proper owner.
- Confirm readiness remains pending the necessary handoff checks.

Add a complication: A manager wants attendance at the scheduled session counted as completed enablement.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Platform, APIs, and Technical Debt

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

SITUATION

A team can add a requested feature quickly using a workaround or spend longer improving the underlying interface.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

technical debt - Future work arising from design or implementation choices that make later changes harder.

API - Application programming interface; a defined way for software systems to exchange data or trigger actions.

platform - A foundational technology or system that supports several applications or products.

reliability - The ability to perform an intended function consistently under stated conditions over time.

3. Notice the language

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Compare this wording: This option is more better.

LESSON 07 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Explain a fair comparison

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence expresses a clear contrast?
 - A. Option A is faster, so option B costs less.
 - B. Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.
 - C. Option A is faster because option B costs less.
2. A rate increases from 6% to 7%. What is the absolute difference?
 - A. An increase of one percentage point.
 - B. An increase of one percent relative to the original rate.
 - C. An increase of seven percentage points.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Fast workaround or a stronger interface

Fictional platform discussion using the lesson case: a workaround could deliver sooner, while improving the underlying interface would take longer.

01 • Business sponsor: Can we choose the workaround since it delivers the requested feature sooner?

02 • Product manager: We can compare it with the interface improvement, but speed shouldn't be our only criterion.

03 • Business sponsor: What else belongs beside delivery time when explaining this tradeoff to nontechnical stakeholders?

04 • Product manager: Maintenance effort, reliability evidence, affected users, and the cost of revisiting the workaround later.

05 • Business sponsor: Is that what you mean by technical debt: work we may need to repay through future changes?

06 • Product manager: Yes, broadly. Here we should describe the specific maintenance obligation rather than use the phrase as a warning.

07 • Business sponsor: Do we have confirmed reliability results for both options, or are we comparing assumptions?

08 • Product manager: Those results are not provided yet. We'll label estimates and request the engineering assessment.

09 • Business sponsor: I'll consider a bounded workaround if its limits and follow-up ownership are explicit.

10 • Product manager: I'll bring comparable options and conditions before asking you to choose a delivery approach.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

One customer exception or a reusable API change

Fictional platform planning: one customer requests an extra response field; the team can assess a customer-specific exception or a shared API change.

01 • Account manager: Could engineering add the field only for this customer so we avoid a platform discussion?

02 • Platform product manager: That option needs comparison with a shared application programming interface, or API, change.

03 • Account manager: Why consider a broader change when only one customer has asked for the field so far?

04 • Platform product manager: A special case may add maintenance and testing obligations. A shared change may affect more consumers.

05 • Account manager: So neither option is automatically better simply because its visible scope looks smaller or larger.

06 • Platform product manager: Correct. Compare delivery effort, compatibility, reliability checks, and future support using the same criteria.

07 • Account manager: Can you promise the exception now while the shared design is still being assessed?

08 • Platform product manager: No. We haven't established its effort or safety for existing consumers, so timing remains unconfirmed.

09 • Account manager: I'll tell the customer the request is under assessment and explain which tradeoff we are reviewing.

10 • Platform product manager: I'll return with bounded options rather than make a platform commitment from an unreviewed exception.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A manual retry hides recurring maintenance work

Fictional product operations: a failing import sometimes succeeds after a manual retry; the cause and frequency are not yet quantified.

01 • Operations lead: Manual retry often completes the import. Could we keep that workaround instead of prioritizing a fix?

02 • Product manager: We should compare its ongoing support burden with the effort and expected benefit of investigating the interface.

03 • Operations lead: We don't have a reliable failure frequency yet, so the burden is still an estimate.

04 • Product manager: Then let's measure incidents and staff time before calling the workaround cheap or the fix unnecessary.

05 • Operations lead: Would you label this technical debt even though the immediate customer task can eventually finish?

06 • Product manager: The recurring manual obligation is the useful detail. The label alone doesn't establish priority or cause.

07 • Operations lead: Can we keep reporting successful retries while making the unresolved reliability issue visible?

08 • Product manager: Yes. Recovery success and first-attempt reliability answer different questions and should be tracked separately.

09 • Operations lead: I'll bring a consistent record of failures, retries, and handling time to the next prioritization review.

10 • Product manager: Then we can compare options on evidence instead of assuming hidden work costs nothing.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Platform, APIs, and Technical Debt

A team can add a requested feature quickly using a workaround or spend longer improving the underlying interface.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Second round: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Model for scenario 1: The workaround is faster initially, while the interface change may reduce future maintenance. Let's compare delivery time, reliability, and ongoing cost instead of considering only the first release date.

Scenario 2 | Supporting two API versions

A fictional platform supports version 1, and a proposed version 2 would simplify a new feature. Existing customer migration effort is unknown. Compare maintaining both versions with a reviewed migration approach without announcing a retirement date.

Role A: Platform product manager: outline common comparison criteria.

Role B: Customer-success lead: raise unknown migration and support needs.

Possible opening: Version two may simplify the feature, but we haven't assessed what existing customers need to migrate.

Success checks

- Compare delivery, maintenance, compatibility, and customer effort.
- Keep migration assumptions explicit.
- Avoid promising retirement or migration dates without assessment.

Add a complication: A stakeholder says a newer version makes migration effort irrelevant.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

Stakeholder Pushback and Executive Narrative

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

SITUATION

Two executives disagree about a product decision. The meeting has competing opinions but no shared criterion.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

stakeholder - Person or group with an interest, risk, authority, or dependency in the work.

strategic fit - How well an option supports an organization's objectives and capabilities.

tradeoff - A choice that improves one objective while giving up something on another.

decision memo - A concise document presenting a decision question, options, evidence, and recommendation.

3. Notice the language

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Compare this wording: Nobody objected, so everyone agrees.

LESSON 08 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Help a group reach a clear next step

4. Check the language

1. Which phrase invites a missing perspective?
 - A. We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view?
 - B. The remote team has been quiet, so they must agree.
 - C. We can record their agreement without asking them.
2. Which closing statement records an unresolved decision accurately?
 - A. We discussed the options, so approval is complete.
 - B. Everyone spoke, so the decision must be final.
 - C. Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Agree a criterion before choosing a feature

Fictional executive discussion using the lesson case: two executives favor different product options without a shared decision criterion.

01 • Product manager: We have competing preferences. Could we agree the decision criterion before selecting either product option?

02 • Executive sponsor: One executive values expansion, while the other wants stronger retention. Neither has defined the priority.

03 • Product manager: Let's invite both to explain strategic fit and the outcome each option is expected to support.

04 • Executive sponsor: Would collecting their opinions again simply repeat the disagreement without moving us forward?

05 • Product manager: We should ask for evidence and tradeoffs, then clarify who has the authority to decide.

06 • Executive sponsor: I'll confirm the decision owner. We also need the support team's view of the operational impact.

07 • Product manager: Agreed. Their perspective belongs in the discussion before any recommendation becomes a decision memo.

08 • Executive sponsor: Can you summarize what is unresolved at the end rather than claim consensus from a quiet room?

09 • Product manager: Yes: shared criterion, operational impact, and confirmed decision ownership remain the immediate questions.

10 • Executive sponsor: I'll bring the relevant voices together so the next discussion can reach an accountable next step.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Revenue potential and onboarding effort

Fictional product review: sales favors a specialist feature, while customer success questions onboarding effort; neither impact estimate is verified.

01 • Product director: Sales wants the specialist feature, but customer success has concerns. How should we frame this decision?

02 • Product manager: Let's hear both views using the same criteria: expected customer value, onboarding effort, and strategic fit.

03 • Product director: Sales has a revenue estimate. Does that settle the tradeoff before we hear support concerns?

04 • Product manager: The estimate is unverified, and operational effort is also unverified. Neither should be treated as established.

05 • Product director: Then invite the owners to explain their assumptions rather than argue over whose forecast sounds stronger.

06 • Product manager: I'll do that and distinguish evidence, estimates, and unknowns in the decision discussion.

07 • Product director: Who should decide whether this feature belongs ahead of the existing roadmap commitments?

08 • Product manager: We should confirm that authority through our planning process instead of assuming this meeting can approve it.

09 • Product director: Good. Close with the evidence needed and the decision owner, not an implied commitment to sales.

10 • Product manager: I'll capture those next steps and preserve any remaining disagreement accurately in the decision memo.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A loud meeting does not equal stakeholder agreement

Fictional product meeting: an executive strongly supports a redesign; the accessibility lead has not spoken and review findings remain unknown.

01 • Executive sponsor: The redesign has strong support in this room. Can we say stakeholders are aligned?

02 • Product manager: We haven't heard from the accessibility lead, and their review findings aren't available yet.

03 • Executive sponsor: Could we record alignment now and add their comments when they eventually arrive?

04 • Product manager: That would imply agreement we haven't obtained. We can record the current preference and pending review separately.

05 • Executive sponsor: Please invite their perspective, but keep the discussion focused on the decision we actually need.

06 • Product manager: I'll ask which findings affect the proposed scope and what remains unassessed, without assuming their conclusion.

07 • Executive sponsor: And how do we avoid turning every unresolved detail into an indefinite product delay?

08 • Product manager: Confirm the decision owner and the evidence they need, then agree a review checkpoint.

09 • Executive sponsor: That works. I'll help establish the decision route rather than ask you to manufacture consensus.

10 • Product manager: I'll summarize support, pending input, and the next decision step as distinct parts of the executive narrative.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Stakeholder Pushback and Executive Narrative

Two executives disagree about a product decision. The meeting has competing opinions but no shared criterion.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Second round: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Model for scenario 1: Could we agree on the outcome and decision criteria first? Then we can compare the options against them, record the tradeoff, and confirm who will make the final decision.

Scenario 2 | A strategic-fit claim without a named objective

A fictional proposal is described as strategically essential, but the sponsor has not identified which current product objective it supports. The team has two competing proposals. Facilitate a short comparison and clarify the decision route.

Role A: Product manager: ask for the objective and relevant evidence.

Role B: Executive sponsor: explain the intended outcome while acknowledging the missing comparison.

Possible opening: Which product objective does this proposal support, and what criterion should we use to compare it with the alternative?

Success checks

- Connect strategic fit to a named objective or an explicit gap.
- Preserve the relevant competing perspective.
- Agree criteria and decision ownership without implying approval.

Add a complication: The sponsor asks you to omit the alternative from the decision discussion.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response to scenario 1, not a script to memorize. Assess your spoken version using the four criteria at the end.

01 | Product Discovery and Problem Framing

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Check 1: B - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

B: The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".

C: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

Check 2: A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

B: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

C: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

Model response: What is the user trying to achieve, and where do they get stuck? Let's examine that problem before deciding whether a new button is the right solution.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Roadmaps and Prioritization

Editing example: If you approve the scope, we can assess the schedule.

For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Check 1: A - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule.

A: The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.

B: For this ordinary future condition, use present simple in the "if" clause.

C: "Reviewed" places the response in the past instead of expressing the future response.

Check 2: C - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope.

A: It treats unreviewed work as already included.

B: It promises an outcome without examining the consequences.

C: This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

Model response: We have capacity for two features in this period. Could we compare the expected outcomes and dependencies, then agree which item moves? Calling all three urgent does not resolve the capacity choice.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | User Stories and Acceptance Criteria

Editing example: Could you send the missing document and confirm when it will be available?

The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Check 1: C - Send it no later than Thursday.

A: "By Thursday" permits earlier delivery; it is not restricted to that day.

B: This interprets a deadline as a continuing activity, which would use "until".

C: 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.

Check 2: B - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?

A: This checks receipt, not which version is required for the review.

B: The requested action and information are explicit.

C: This checks importance rather than identifying the needed document version.

Model response: Could we define the relevant user journey, measurement conditions, and acceptable response time? That will make the acceptance criteria clear enough for development and testing.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | Metrics, Funnels, and Product Analytics

Editing example: We need to put the plan into practice.

The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Check 1: B - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.

A: This describes capacity, not the work waiting to be completed.

B: This gives the meaning in familiar words.

C: Completed work is different from work still waiting.

Check 2: A - How would you describe the next step in your own words?

A: An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

B: Offering repetition may help, but it does not show how the listener understood the next step.

C: This invites an opinion on detail, not a demonstration of understanding.

Model response: Sign-ups increased, but setup completion fell. These metrics describe different stages of the funnel. Let's examine the full journey before concluding that the change improved the intended user outcome.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Experimentation and A/B Testing

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: A - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

B: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

C: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

Check 2: C - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

B: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

C: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

Model response: The early observed rate is higher, but the planned test is incomplete. I'll report it as an interim result and check the agreed analysis and guardrail measures before recommending a decision.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | Release Readiness and Go-to-Market

Editing example: Please confirm which team has accepted the follow-up task.

The revised sentence asks for an identifiable receiving team instead of leaving responsibility with an unspecified 'someone'.

Check 1: C - Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check.

A: Mentioning a task does not show that anyone accepted it.

B: A written record alone does not identify who will act.

C: It asks for an identifiable person or team responsible for the task.

Check 2: B - So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct?

A: Receiving a message is not the same as confirming its meaning.

B: This repeats the status and responsibility and invites correction.

C: It changes pending information into a final result.

Model response: The product checks are ready for review; support preparation is still open. I'll send the migration notes and ask the support owner to confirm readiness before the launch decision.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Platform, APIs, and Technical Debt

Editing example: This option is better on cost, but slower to deliver.

'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Check 1: B - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.

A: 'So' implies one fact causes the other.

B: 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.

C: 'Because' claims a causal connection that is not given.

Check 2: A - An increase of one percentage point.

A: Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

B: A one-percent relative increase on 6% would be 6.06%, not 7%.

C: The new rate is 7%; the difference between the rates is one percentage point.

Model response: The workaround is faster initially, while the interface change may reduce future maintenance. Let's compare delivery time, reliability, and ongoing cost instead of considering only the first release date.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | Stakeholder Pushback and Executive Narrative

Editing example: Before I record agreement, does anyone have a concern or need more time?

The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

Check 1: A - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view?

A: It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.

B: Silence does not establish agreement.

C: Recording agreement without checking may misrepresent the team's view.

Check 2: C - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options.

A: Discussion does not itself constitute approval.

B: Participation alone does not establish a decision.

C: This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

Model response: Could we agree on the outcome and decision criteria first? Then we can compare the options against them, record the tradeoff, and confirm who will make the final decision.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Practice grammar in context

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Software Product Management English

Professional audience: software product managers, product owners, UX leads, engineering managers, growth product teams, platform PMs, and product-operations staff

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Product Discovery and Problem Framing

Original fictional case: A stakeholder requests a new button without explaining the user problem. Support notes mention difficulty finding an existing action.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: user need: Something a user needs to accomplish in a particular context. / persona: A research-informed representation of a user group used to guide design or communication. / use case: A specific situation describing how someone uses a product or service to achieve a goal. / opportunity cost: The value of the best alternative given up when choosing an option.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: What is the user trying to achieve, and where do they get stuck? Let's examine that problem before deciding whether a new button is the right solution.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Grammar that changes the meaning

1. For a lesson, use its language workshop as the focus. For a dialogue, quote one actual sentence and select one useful grammar feature from it, such as question word order, tense, modality, conditionals or clause linking. Explain in no more than 90 words how this feature helps the speakers do their work. Keep the grammar target narrow.
2. Give two short contrasting sentences using this workplace context. Explain the difference in time, certainty, condition or politeness. Label invented examples and preserve the distinction between possible, planned and confirmed events. Describe context-dependent choices as choices, not universal rules.
3. Give me one editing or sentence-building task using a known case fact. Do not copy the supplied editing example or reveal its answer. Ask me to explain my intended meaning. Stop and wait.
4. After I answer, quote my wording, identify at most two issues, and give a brief explanation and one hint. Ask me to revise before offering a full corrected version. Then accept any accurate, natural alternative that serves the purpose.
5. Continue with two new tasks, one at a time: first guided, then an original response without a sentence frame. End with a two-sentence workplace message using the target feature and a compact self-check. Do not replace this sequence with a worksheet and answer key.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level